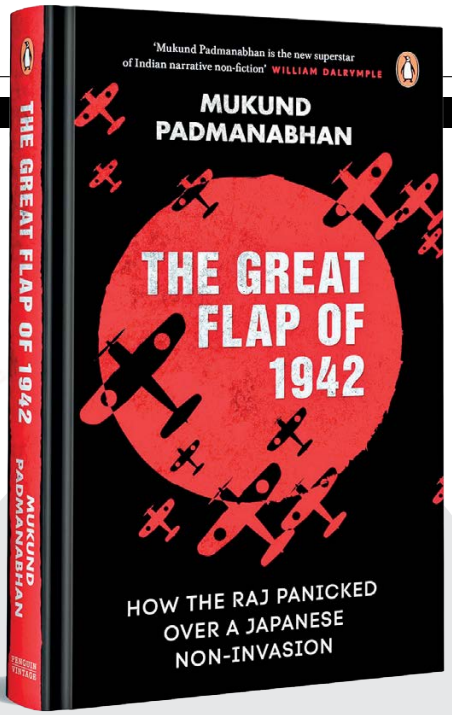
BOOKS

THE WAR THAT WASN'T

MUKUND PADMANABHAN'S *THE GREAT FLAP OF 1942* SPOTLIGHTS AN INTERESTING MOMENT IN COLONIAL INDIAN HISTORY WHEN THE POSSIBILITY OF A JAPANESE INVASION SEEMED VERY REAL



THE GREAT FLAP OF 1942
How the Raj Panicked Over a Japanese Non-invasion
by Mukund Padmanabhan
PENGUIN VINTAGE
₹599; 272 pages

The Great Flap of 1942 ends with the summary execution of the "lions, tigers, panthers, bears and venomous snakes" of Madras Zoo by the Malabar Special Police on April 14, 1942. The killings were the culmination of a widespread hysteria occasioned by the prospect of a Japanese invasion of South India in 1942, an invasion that never materialised. Mukund Padmanabhan's book then tells us the story of an event that never took place, chronicling the panic that swept much of India as Japanese forces rampaged through Southeast Asia and the Indian Ocean in the first few months of Asia's Second World War. Japan's many victories excited fears about bombing throughout the Raj, causing coastal cities such as Calcutta, Cochin, Madras and Bombay to empty of civilians. Government offices relocated to sleepy provincial towns, where rents promptly shot up even as hastily abandoned properties were burgled.

Padmanabhan's prose is fantastic without becoming florid. Japan's invasion ripped "apart like a muslin an Empire that was woven purposefully over centuries". In other parts, the book evinces a wry black humour such as when Calcutta's Scottish Police Commissioner was forced to rebut the rumour that he had been jailed for being an "Irish retarder". The book is a racy read in which Padmanabhan's punchy journalistic style shines. The book is also remarkably well-researched, drawing on sources from across India and the United Kingdom. It makes several important revisions to received narratives of India's Second World War. Padmanabhan points to the role of India in Japanese strategy as well as anxieties about Japanese aggression in the Raj, particularly in Madras province where the Japanese threat was far more worrying than the possibility of war with the Soviet Union. He also points to the critical importance of the early Japanese victories in shaping Indian responses to the Cripps Mission. Where earlier the failure of proposals made by Cripps was treated as a foregone conclusion, Padmanabhan argues that the belief

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